

DESKTOP REPLACEMENTS

As the name suggests, these laptops are built to retire the bulky desktop PC without compromising on the performance aspect. They takes up lesser amounts of space than a normal PC, and offer certain amount of mobility. Desktop replacements are bulky and weigh above 3.5 Kgs, making them the heaviest among all notebook categories. Their thickness varies with the components and the number of connectors present on the laptop. In fact, some of them may not come with batteries, and hence need a constant power supply.

Since desktop replacements are supposed to fill in for a full-fledged PCs, they have all the ports available on a standard sys-

tem, and at the same time, perform just as well. While buying a desktop replacement, pay attention to the screen size, the available hard disk space and the type of hard disk. Many might come with a normal IDE hard disk that is cheaper than most small laptop hard disks. Do remember to make a note of the processor and the amount of RAM you require for doing your tasks, especially if you use memory-intensive applications such as Photoshop. Large comfortable keyboards, tabs on the under surface that incline the keyboard at an angle, and other such features add to its comfort levels.

ACi Ultima

Portable theatre

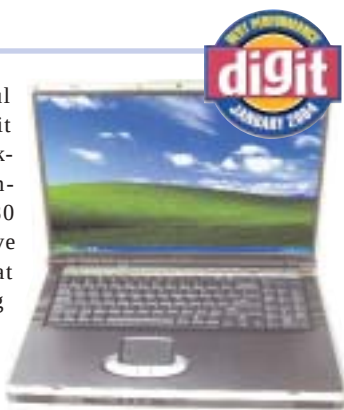
The ACi Ultima is powerful and well-balanced—it cramps in a standard desktop Pentium4 2.26 GHz, a mammoth 1 GB of DDR RAM, an 80 GB hard drive and a combo-drive as well. The 17-inch wide format TFT gives you a great viewing experience.

The outer casing is finished in silver. Weighing 4.1 Kgs, it packs in a standard keyboard with jet-black keys and bright white inscriptions. The touchpad is slightly offset towards the left. This comes in the way while using the number-pad keys. Placing it in the dead centre would have improved its ergonomics.

Other features included are an integrated Web-camera and a TV-tuner with a remote control. The air exhaust ports are underneath—hardly 5 mm above the desk. Thus, air is pushed towards the keyboard causing the keys to heat up. The base was a searing 45 degrees Celsius by the time the test concluded.

Performance-wise, the Business Winstone score was amongst the best, but we expected more. The Pentium 2.26 GHz passed the CPU test with flying colours. The memory, as well as the hard disk, also returned commendable scores. This system can handle any resource-hungry application without a hitch. The onboard Radeon 9000 graphics adapter turned in a good frame rate in *Quake III* and *Unreal Tournament*, but don't expect the same performance when playing *Half-Life2*, *Halo 2* or any new games.

Though a wee bit expensive at Rs 1,20,000, there is no other laptop that can match the ACi Ultima's combination of configuration and looks.



Price: Rs 1,20,000
+ Amazing wide-format LCD screen, good looks
- Emits a lot of heat

ACi Ultima		C-
Performance		
Features		
Usability		
Value for money		

ACi Emerald Pro

Call it the diamond

The ACi Emerald Pro pushes the performance envelope further by including a desktop Pentium 3.06 GHz CPU, 512 MB of RAM, a 40 GB hard disk, a combo-drive and a 15-inch TFT LCD. The Radeon 9000 graphics adapter makes a wonderful graphics sub-system.

The good use of colour combination gives this muscular laptop a distinct character. Weighing 3.5 Kgs, it was the lightest, and also the thinnest in this category. The keyboard is not as comfortable as the one on the Ultima. Due to its reduced size, a full-size keyboard was omitted. The touchpad is again biased to the left, and causes some discomfort. The touchpad buttons are stiff, and require quite an effort to click. This laptop also comes with an integrated Web cam that's placed just above the LCD.

The Emerald Pro seared to 40 degrees—even the keyboard and touchpad get hot due to the trapped heat.

On the performance front, the Hyper-threaded CPU and the 512 MB of RAM yielded excellent results. It finished video encoding in just 95 seconds—the fastest in the entire comparison. Similarly, the Business Winstone returned a high score of 27, an indication of its capability to handle resource-hungry applications. The gaming benchmarks also saw the laptop returning some terrific scores. Despite such power-hungry components, the battery can still last for 2 hours and 18 minutes.

Priced at Rs 74,000 it offers a great price-to-performance ratio—just as long as you carry a portable air conditioner.



Price: Rs 74,000
+ A good configuration, great performance
- Gets heated, lacks aesthetic appeal

ACi Emerald Pro		B+
Performance		
Features		
Usability		
Value for money		